Emotional Baggage

By Nina Shengold

(A near-empty baggage claim carousel at Newark Airport. A few stray suitcases circle forlornly. Actors shuffle around the periphery of the stage shoulder to shoulder, as if swept along by a rotating belt. PHYLLIS stands crookedly, leaning on DICK as if thrown there.)

DICK *(an irate Samsonite pullman):* This sucks. *(PHYLLIS and DICK turn in unison, facing the side wall as the "carousel" circles upstage. DICK looks back over his shoulder.)* How many times have [we] been around?

PHYLLIS *(a panicky carry-on bag)*: I'm dizzy. My straps hurt. I'm going to catch cold!

DICK: Quit whining. *(Shouts into the wings.)* YO, HEY!!! COME AND GET ME, YOU MORON!!! Do you know what I weigh? I'm a Samsonite hardbody!

PHYLLIS: Please! I've got mal de mer! *(The carousel shuts off abruptly. They lurch to a sudden stop.)* It stopped! The belt, the, the thing . . . it's not

DICK: *(hissed whisper)* Cheese it, the crew. Look inanimate. Sssh! *(DICK freezes in place. PHYLLIS continues to panic for a beat, then freezes suddenly)*

CREW: *(A voice booms from off stage)* LOOKS LIKE WE GOT US A COUPLE OF UNCLAIMED BAGS. LUG 'EM. *(PHYLLIS and DICK are "lifted" in unison, shoulders pulled up toward the ceiling as if picked up by giant hands)*

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INTRODUCTION

It's a traveler's worst nightmare to discover that the airline has lost your luggage—waiting at baggage claim for your bag to emerge, but it never does. But what if the opposite happens? You've probably seen it—the bags have come out onto the baggage carousel. Most of the travelers have found their bags and gone on their way. But, if you're one of the last people lingering at the carousel, you've probably noticed one or two bags left, going around and around, over and over, with no one claiming them. What happens if no one does?

From the perspective of those unclaimed pieces of luggage . . . . Emotional Baggage by Nina Shengold.

PHYLLIS: Where are they taking us??

DICK: Lockup. The big house . . . Unclaimed baggage. *(The unseen hands "throw" them down onto a luggage rack.)*

PHYLLIS: Oh God! *(fearfully)* Who are those other bags? *(AMBER saunters on, followed by ROLLO and MILDRED.)*

DICK: Looks like rough trade. Maybe lifers.

AMBER *(an over the hill overnight bag):* Hey, big boy! Is that a travel umbrella, or are you glad to see me? *(She barks a short, humorless laugh and plunks into a chair with her arm around PHYLLIS.)*

PHYLLIS: OhGodOhGodOhGodOhGOD!!!

ROLLO *(a beat-up drug smuggler's duffel)*: *(sitting on PHYLLIS 's other side)* Chill, babe. What are you, a carry-on?

PHYLLIS: Yes! I'm a carry-on! I was made to be carried! I would have been carried if she hadn't bought so much Duty-Free Tia Maria! I was flying First Class!

MILDRED *(a dignified, threadbare valise from the South)*: So was I, my dear. So was I. *(She sits with a thud.)*

ROLLO: What're you in for?

PHYLLIS: Beg pardon?

ROLLO: Lost tag, missed connection? You're just off the plane from Cancun, right?

PHYLLIS: I flew down for a Realtors' convention!

ROLLO: Did the beagle sniff you? I hate it when they sniff you.

DICK: Leave her alone, or I'll pop you one right in the buckle.

ROLLO: Big man. I'm aquiver. First time in the joint? *(PHYLLIS nods)* We got some hard cases. Watch out for that camp trunk. And Rolf there, that rucksack, he'd eat you for breakfast. Most of the rest? Just a buncha lost luggage.

PHYLLIS: So what happens now?

AMBER: We wait. For our legs.

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PHYLLIS: How long?

ROLLO: Some cases make bail the first night. Some do the whole stretch. Thirty days.

PHYLLIS: But ... I'm carrying beach things rolled in a mesh bag! Her tankini's still damp! I could mildew!

ROLLO: So what? Little mildew won't kill you.

PHYLLIS: I have sand in my twill! *(Breaking down in tears.)* This is not what I thought it would be like at all. You know, when you're still in the warehouse, you dream about having somebody to carry you? Well. First, she removed all my tags. And it says. Right there in capitals: "Do not remove under penalty of law."

ROLLO: Oh, you poor baby. You're fresh from the store?

PHYLLIS: From a catalog! I was just ordered!

ROLLO: Your first trip on a plane? *(PHYLLIS nods.)* And she lost you?? *(She nods again.)* That makes me so mad I could split a seam. Hell needs a separate ring for that kinda behavior. We're gonna take care of you, kiddo.

DICK: I bet you'll take care of her.

ROLLO: Stow it, you steroid-pumped piece a' petroleum. Can't you see the kid's scared?

PHYLLIS: The luggage compartment was bad enough!

MILDRED: Steerage! I was flung cheek by jowl with an R.E.I. backpack. The smell of that bedroll. I thought I'd expire, I most certainly did.

ROLLO: I was next to a dog. *(Murmurs all around. This is bad.)* Uh huh, yeah. Flew up from Miami alongside a doped-up Jack Russell. But not too sedated to squirt me.

PHYLLIS: What are you ... in for?

ROLLO: My [idiot] missed his plane. Checks me in at the counter, right, goes to the men's room, next thing you know he's in Boca Raton and yours truly is doing the carousel cha-cha in Newark. Again. I wish he would just lose me.

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PHYLLIS: You don't really mean that.

ROLLO: Oh no? I came close a few times. Hotel lobby in Bangkok. [He] puts me down and goes out for a smoke. I was sure I'd be lifted, you know, do a stint on the black market? Wrong. No one looked at me twice. I could've been a container. Instead of a bum, which is what I am.

PHYLLIS: I think you're kind of cute.

ROLLO: Don't melt my heart with that garbage. I'm nobody's treasure chest. What's your monogram, kid?

PHYLLIS: P.M.S.

ROLLO: Aw. That's so sweet. My name's Rollo. What's that you got rolled in that towel?

AMBER: What've you got, x-ray eyes?

ROLLO: You been through as many detectors as I have, you've got x-ray everything.

DICK: This guy's full of [crap]. He's a con man!

ROLLO: Whatever you need to believe. Though if I had those magazines sewn in my lining . . .

DICK: How did you know that??

ROLLO: We ain't so opaque as we think, my man. Not if you know how to look.

DICK: It's a trick!

ROLLO: Hey, I've done tricks. False bottoms, lead x-ray blocks. Not anymore. I got nothin' to hide. What you see is what is. I've had some hard knocks, done the merchant marine, rode the rails outta Marrakech next to a goat. I ain't sayin' I ain't got some miles on me. But I'm ready to kick all that, settle down, have a coupla fanny packs with the right girl. End of the day, it's who you got loving you.

MILDRED: Even love doesn't last. I married a satchel, raised three matching garment bags. Where are they now? Do they call? Do they write?

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AMBER: I used to hang out with a weekender bag, name of Morty. He would've gone to the ends of the earth for me! He was the genuine article. Leather. Top-grain. They don't make 'em like that anymore.

MILDRED: They're all microfiber. Synthetic.

ROLLO: Uh-oh. Here it comes.

MILDRED: Back in my day- We were valises back then. We were carried by uniformed porters. Cunard Lines. The steamer trunks! Bandboxes! Linings of satin. Solid brass fittings.

DICK: Yeah, right. And your ancestors rode on the Mayflower. Well, la di dah.

MILDRED: Thug!

DICK: Dust collector. White elephant!

ROLLO: *(Pulls DICK aside, confidential.)* Go easy on her. She's on day twenty-nine of a thirty-day stretch. And the old bag don't know about this, but her legs had a cardiac thirty-five thou in the air over Greenland. He ain't coming back.

PHYLLIS: What ... what'll happen to her?

ROLLO: The daughter-in-law picks her up, checks her insides for valuables, doesn't find nothing, she sends Portmanteau down the Red Mile.

PHYLLIS: *(in horror)* The Salvation Army??

ROLLO: She got Clearance Sale written all over her tweed.

PHYLLIS: *(rising panic)* I want to get out of here! Somebody CLAIM me!!!

ROLLO: Hey, hey, hey. Kid, that ain't you. You're just outta the warehouse, ya dig? You got miles of blue sky up ahead.

CREW: *(offstage)* CAN I HELP YOU? COULD I SEE YOUR CLAIM CHECK? *(The suitcases sit forward, waiting expectantly. PHYLLIS closes her eyes tightly, crossing her fingers.)*

PHYLLIS: Me. Me.

CREW: *(offstage)* YUP. IT'S RIGHT OVER THERE. *(Loud sound of footsteps. The suitcases*

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hold their breath, hopeful. Suddenly DICK is "pulled up" by the shoulder. He is "carried" off, The others sit stunned.)

PHYLLIS: He got picked up?? Out of all of us? Him?? *(voice starting to tremble)* I'll never get home now.

AMBER: Quit snivelling. We're all on the shelf.

ROLLO: Drop the attitude, will you? You're luggage. You're Naugahyde, buddy. A knockoff. A fake. *(Sotto voice.)* I see dead baggage. The future, the past. I can't help it. I always have. Thing is, most people, they don't wanna know.

PHYLLIS: Can you see my future? My Realtor is gonna come back for me, right? I'll be found?

ROLLO: *(Hesitates, doesn't like lying.)* ... Sure, kid. Of course, you will. Here, put your strap on my shoulder.

PHYLLIS: Thanks, Rollo. *(She settles her head on his shoulder, then puts her thumb in her mouth. ROLLO strokes her hair softly.)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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